Babyhood

By Paul Reiser

NOTE: *Narration from the book (non-conversational) has been assigned to either "Mom" or "Dad" – There is no speaker designation for narration within the text. Check with the DUO rules in your state before performing.*

MOM: **(Pg 4-5)** What if we want to travel?

DAD: You can travel with kids

MOM: Not to Africa

DAD: Who's going to Africa?

MOM: I'm just saying hypothetically. What if we wanted to pick up and go to Africa?

DAD: Do you want to go to Africa?

MOM: Not particularly

DAD: So?

MOM: But, someday, I might . . .

DAD: The problem with this type of argument is that on closer inspection, when you list all the things you fear you'd have to give up if you had a kid . . .

MOM: You can't help but notice it's actually a pretty pitiful list.

DAD: What else? What specifically are you afraid you're not going to be able to do with a kid that you do now?

MOM: Okay – sleep?

DAD: Fine. Are we really going to forgo being parents so we can nap?

MOM: Maybe. . . And what about going to the movies?

DAD: You can still go to the movies with kids.

MOM: Yeah, but not whenever I want.

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INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *It's the best thing in the world . . .*
ACTRESS: *It's certainly not easy, and it does change your life forever, but it really is true.*
TOGETHER: *There is nothing more rewarding or wonderful than having children.*
ACTRESS: *At least that's what they tell you . . . .*
ACTOR: *Babyhood by Paul Reiser*

DAD: **(Pg 32)** You know, it may not definitely be true. These things aren't always a hundred percent accurate.

MOM: The stick is blue

DAD: Yeah, but not by a lot. All I'm saying is, it's barely blue. It's a very light blue. Like 'sky blue.' Sort of 'bad rental tuxedo blue'

MOM: This, pal, is what they call 'baby blue'

DAD: But I think it's supposed to be dark blue. Like navy blue.

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DAD: **(Pg 48-49)** Why are you crying?

MOM: I don't know.

DAD: Do you want me to get you anything?

MOM: No, I'm nauseous.

DAD: How many bananas did you have?

MOM: Eight.

DAD: *(to audience)* Well, there you go. That might be part of the problem. *(to Mom)* Honey, next time maybe don't eat so many bananas at one time. . . Is there anything I can do for you?

MOM: Yeah – shut up and leave me alone.

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MOM: **(Pg 95-96)** I want you to promise you'll remarry . . . If anything ever happens to me, I want you to marry someone and get on with your life.

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DAD: What are you talking about?

MOM: I'm serious

DAD: You're going to be fine. Nothing's going to happen

MOM: It might. You don't know. What was that movie . . . ? The movie where the mother was giving birth and they helped pull out the baby but the mother died?

DAD: City Slickers? (Mom nods, scared to death) Sweetie, that was a cow.

MOM: Even so . . . she thought everything was going to be fine, too, and then look what happened.

DAD: **(Pg 99)** *(to audience)* At this point my wife contorted in pain and then everything became a blur. There was a chunk of time – I couldn't tell you how long it lasted . .

(following lines are spoken simultaneously and with a rising level of franticness)

MOM: Doctors came in	**DAD:** Nurses scurried about
Machines were wheeled around	Mirrors were brought in
Everybody was talking	and moving
And coaching	and touching
And prodding	and sponging
And gloving	and crying
And pulling	and crowding

MOM: *(Let's out a huge yell as the baby arrives . . . . then all is silent . . . stunned silence)*

DAD: **(Pg 100)** The next thing I remember was the doctor gleefully pronouncing: It's a boy! Would you like to cut the cord? *(Facial expression of apprehension and slight disgust)*

MOM: **(Pg 103)** Sometime later, the three of us – now and forever a family – went home.

DAD: **(Pg 109)** A new child in the house is a huge tourist attraction.

MOM: It's like Disney land, except there the lines are longer and no one brings casseroles.

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DAD: **(PG 111 – 112)** Everybody wants to talk to babies, but no one knows what to say.

MOM: "Hello" is very popular. You can't not say it. You pick up a baby, you just start saying "Hello". Over and over.

DAD: "Hello...hello...hellllll-ooooo..." Like you're on the phone and the baby's just not picking up.

MOM: Usually what comes next is a question.

DAD: The inevitably high-pitched, dopey-voiced, grown-ups-talking-to-babies voice.

MOM: "Who's the cutest baby?"

DAD: "Who's got an itty-bitty nose?"

MOM: "Who's got a poopy diaper? You? Do you have a poopy diaper and an itty-bitty nose?"

DAD: First of all, these questions are way too easy. The reason babies don't answer is because they're insulted. They don't like being patronized.

MOM: **(Pg 113)** Or they just lean over the baby and make amusing noises

DAD: Ha-cha-cha—cha . . . Ha-cha-cha-cha . . . Boo-ta-boo-ta . . . Coochie coochie coo (realizes he's being watched and assumes a more dignified stance)

MOM: **(Pg 115)** [But] We had no idea how one starts the process of actually being parents.

DAD: **(Pg 129)** What's the difference between couplehood and babyhood?

TOGETHER: Moisture *(the following lines are spoken simultaneously)*

MOM: Your spittle	**DAD:** Your diapers
Your spit-up	And drool
You got your baby food	Your wipes
Your formula	Your leaky bottles
Sweaty baby backs	And numerous other untraceable sources

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MOM: **(Pg 130)** Before we go any further, allow me to take a moment to clarify the various categories of moisture . . . There's spit

DAD: which is the wet stuff that's in your baby's mouth

MOM: Spittle

DAD: spit that's left the mouth and is hanging off your baby's face in long, suspended, pendulous gobs . . . and drool

MOM: Which is secreted during sleep and collects in large, lukewarm pools.

DAD: And, last but certainly not least. Spit-up *(gag reflex)* which is hot, lumpy, and frankly too repulsive to discuss any further.

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MOM: **(Pg 225)** In the beginning, whatever sleeping schedule your baby makes up, you accept.

DAD: But after a few months, for the sake of your own sanity, you have to take matters into your own hands.

MOM: **(pg 224)** [But] when he's in the next room screaming at four in the morning one of you has to stumble out of your warm bed to deal with it.

(During this section both actor and actress provide crying sound effects while the other speaks)

DAD: It turns out there's a popular school of thoughts that maintains the best thing you can do for your child is to teach them to soothe themselves to sleep.

MOM: In short – let 'em cry???? That's the whole trick???? leave them alone????

DAD: **(pg 225)** There's a book [that] says you're supposed to let them cry for five minutes, then you can pat them a little bit.

MOM: I'm going in . . . he's crying!

DAD: Don't – the book said . . .

MOM: I don't care about the book, he's crying!

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DAD: If we don't do it, we're going to be his slaves for the rest of our lives. Do you want that? *(crying continues)*

MOM: Is it five minutes yet? How long has it been?

DAD: Eleven seconds *(panic-stricken looks as scene ends)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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